

Sitting With All Beings

Katagiri Roshi's Teachings on *Fukanzazengi*,
Zen Master Dōgen's *Universal Recommendation for Zazen*

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Chapter 1: Universal Recommendation for Zazen

Title

普勸坐禪儀

Fukan zazen gi

Universal Promotion of the Principles of Zazen [EB]

Universally Recommended Instructions for Zazen [SZ]

Universal Recommendation for Zazen [KR]

Commentary

Katagiri Roshi explains the term *zazen*:

Zazen [is] Zen meditation: in Japanese *za zen* (坐禪). *Za* (坐) is “sitting.” *Zen* (禪) is zen, “tranquility.”

I always use the term *zazen*, because the *zazen* we do is a little different from the meditation that [...] other religions do. That’s why I want to use the original term *zazen*.

In Chinese, etymologically, the *za* [is that] two persons sit in the universe. (*Transcriber’s Note*: The character *za* 坐 depicts two people 人 sitting on the ground or earth 土.) [...] That [indicates that] you have to sit with more than two beings, [and] not only human beings. You cannot sit alone, so you should sit with more than two beings, on the earth, in the universe – not in your own egoistic, selfish territory. So you must open yourself and sit in the universe; very naturally you have to sit *with* all sentient beings. That is called *sitting*.

And then very naturally [...] *that* sitting is exactly *zen*, tranquility – because all sentient beings around you are exactly sitting with you! So very naturally that is called *zen*: tranquility. You, and the universe, earth, all beings, and all circumstances, [...] become sitting with you, together. This is called *zazen*.

So all we have to do is to do our best to sit in the universe with all sentient beings. That's *all* we have to do.

– From “Katagiri Roshi’s Zazen Instruction” (1981).

This was how Katagiri Roshi introduced *zazen* to a small group of people in 1981. Note that the first thing he talks about is not an exhortation that we should strive for “enlightenment,” nor is it a technique to reach that goal – it’s that we sit with all beings, and not just human beings.

This is a key point, which will come up again and again.

But what do we mean by *all beings*, or *all sentient beings*? This is actually a deep question.

In brief, “all beings” or “all sentient beings” means *everything* – or at least, *everything in our experience*. Katagiri Roshi often referred to “the table,” “the tape recorder,” or “the microphone” in his explanations of Zen Buddhism, presumably because these objects or “beings” were right in front of him. Dōgen Zenji did not really draw a distinction between animate and inanimate beings, visible or invisible beings, or even sentient and insentient beings; he famously taught that “the insentient preach the dharma.” Although we say “all sentient beings,” the understanding is that all beings are in some sense sentient, in some sense *alive*, because they participate with us in the total dynamic working of the universe.

A word that we sometimes use for this is *interdependence*. In a talk on *mindfulness*, Katagiri Roshi explained it like this:

So [mindfulness is] not the *idea* of mindfulness, because... [Let me say] that [your] observation is completely pure, perfectly pure, beyond purity or impurity. Why? Because if you contemplate or if you observe something, your object, [and] *you* observe your object – that is the dualistic sense. [That is] very common. And then you *judge* immediately; [you] think something. That is really taking care of human life according to “one-way traffic.” You never think of *two-way traffic*. Because if you observe your object, the object observes you; in other words, you are *observed by* your object. Subject and object are always interwoven, interacting like this, simultaneously. But our sense is always setting up subject and object [as] separate, and next moment, [instead of seeing] that interaction, we judge it, by our customs or patterns of thinking. So that’s why next moment we stumble. You know? [*He chuckles.*]

Buddhism always sees that subject and object, because this is a very natural situation. But instead of seeing something and judging it [...] by your sense – see something alive *between* [them], *how* subject and object are working together. That is interpenetration, or *interdependence*, we say.

– From “Mindfulness – Talk 3” (March 23, 1984) at 1-6:56

Often we may understand interdependence in an abstract way: all of these things “out there” are interacting and influencing each other. That’s no doubt true, and it’s a fine thing to understand – but what we are talking about here is the interdependence we are actually *experiencing*, right here and right now.

Basically, *zazen* is sitting in this field of interdependence. That’s why Katagiri Roshi says, “All we have to do is to do our best to sit in the universe with all sentient beings. That’s *all* we have to do.”

Also of interest is the definition of *zen* as *tranquility*. The word *zen* originally comes from the Sanskrit word *dhyana*, which is understood in various ways but which is usually translated as *meditation*. So to define Zen as *tranquility* is really pointing at something, a question: what *is* Zen meditation? And what is *tranquility*? How should we understand it? And how do we practice it?

That is basically the topic of *Fukanzazengi*, and of this study guide. We’ll return to this understanding of zen as *tranquility* often, especially in Chapter 13: “Surrender to Tranquility,” where we discuss the term *sanzen*, which is usually translated as “Zen practice.” But it relates to what Katagiri Roshi said above: “So you, and the universe, earth, all beings, and all circumstances, [...] become sitting with you, together. This is called *zazen*.” This is where tranquility and interdependence meet.

It may sound complicated or confusing at first, but it is actually a very simple practice. Katagiri Roshi says about sitting down in *zazen*:

Anyone can do it. Even if you are not Buddhist, or even if you cannot come [to the Zen Center], you can sit down. [...] This is *shikantaza* (whole-hearted sitting). [...] This is *freedom* – open to *everybody*! No exceptions.

That’s why Dōgen Zenji says “Universal Recommendation for Zazen” – *universal* recommendation. It’s really *universal*. [It’s] not only weeding out (that is, removing all weeds) on your own territory. Anyone can do it. Wherever you may be, you can do it.

– From “Fukanzazengi: Dōgen’s Universal Recommendation for Zazen – Talk 3,” June 11, 1979, at 1:02:07.

What does Katagiri Roshi mean when he says that zazen is “not only removing all the weeds on our own territory”?

By “weeds,” Katagiri Roshi means any mental or physical conditions that we don’t like. We can also understand weeds as *karma* – a topic that we will return to – but again, weeds are the kind of karma that we don’t like. Katagiri Roshi says:

But according to a narrow understanding of human life, first you cut off the root of your weeds, and you want to be happy. That’s nice... but it is a narrow understanding. Because you cannot completely cut off the weeds. You cannot destroy weeds. Weeds grow any time, anywhere.

So the important point is arrangement of our circumstances: how to use the weeds. Even the weeds are nothing but being, which is helping all sentient beings.

– From “Fukanzazengi: Dōgen’s Universal Recommendation for Zazen – Talk 1” (June 9, 1979) at 56:36.

It’s important to remember that one of the *all sentient beings* that you sit with is *you*. That means that we sit with all of our sensations, thoughts, emotions, memories, imaginations, et cetera.

Zazen is not about eliminating mental or physical states that we don’t like. Nor, in fact, is it about chasing after mental states that we *do* like. Instead, zazen is about arranging our circumstances – our environment, and our body and mind – so that we can sit *with* all sentient beings. *Sitting with all sentient beings* means sitting in the midst of everything that we are experiencing. That, in turn, means sitting in the midst of the total dynamic working of the whole universe.

This is what Katagiri Roshi means by “not only on our own territory.” Zazen is not a kind of meditation where we are only trying to improve or perfect ourselves, in a narrow way. Nor are we trying to cut ourselves off from this world and its difficulties.

Plainly speaking, this is a different understanding than in some varieties of Buddhism. We will explore this topic in more detail as we go on, especially in Chapter 21: “Dullness and Distraction are Struck Aside.”

But because zazen is just sitting down and being present, that means *anyone* can do this practice. In other words, it is *universal*. Here is how Katagiri Roshi sums up the practice of *shikantaza* (wholehearted sitting), which is the kind of zazen we do:

So, *shikantaza* is arrangement of all things, and then sit down. That's all.

This is really *bodhisattva* practice, to help all sentient beings. If you practice this, your life is really helpful, for you and for others. It is very true. Even though you don't say [anything], somebody realizes. You have something to tell him or her.

So that is *shikantaza* – the zazen you do, mentioned by Buddha. It's pretty difficult for us to understand intellectually, because we are getting the use of always analyzing and synthesizing everything in the dualistic world; it's very difficult to *stop immediately*. That's why even though you stop for a while, you don't appreciate that practice. But this practice is [...] the best way.

We can explain how important this kind of [Buddhist] practice is philosophically, psychologically – but it takes time. That is a huge world, the philosophical background, psychological background. But even though you don't know [it], you can do it – right now, right here. This is a very urgent need; we have to do it. Whoever you are, wherever you may be, you can do it.

For instance, if you are in an office – well still you can do it. If there is no one there, you can sit down in a chair and calm yourself. If you are talking with somebody, you can realize a certain pause, where no words come up. For that time, you can return to yourself, and breathe.

You can do it, okay? Wherever you may go. It's really universal. It's very simple. It's *too* simple to realize. But, this is the best way. Not only for your life in *this* world, but in the next life, in the life after next life, after next next life, continually.

– From “Fukanzazengi: Dōgen's Universal Recommendation for Zazen – Talk 3” (June 11, 1979) at 1:09:51.

This is a small part of a much longer talk which ties together many ideas in *Fukanzazengi*, including this notion of practicing for lifetime after lifetime, and what it

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means to arrange our circumstances. We'll return to those points in the following chapters.

But this is the conclusion: you can do it. Whatever your situation, whether you understand it or not, you can do zazen. This is a *universal* way to benefit both yourself and the entire cosmic situation.